13.1 From internal tool to external service: ACME's next chapter

The Customer Collaboration platform began as an internal workspace where ACME's engineers, account managers, and customer success teams could securely share documents with external partners. Internally, it was straightforward: every employee authenticated through ACME's corporate identity provider, and customers used OAuth-based links connected to their projects. The platform's sharing model—based on a small relationship graph of owners, editors, and viewers—fits neatly within ACME's internal network and trust assumptions.

As the tool gained popularity, customers started requesting more control: their own administrators, more detailed access levels, and private workspaces separate from ACME's staff. The engineering leadership saw an opportunity to turn the internal tool into a commercial product: the Customer Collaboration Cloud (C^3). However, this required rethinking the foundation. What had been a single-tenant service running under ACME's identity domain needed to become a multi-tenant platform capable of serving hundreds of customer organizations, each with its own users, identity providers, and data boundaries.

That transition forced ACME to face a truth familiar to any organization modernizing its authorization system: what worked for a small, trusted group doesn't scale as the group grows. The internal version of the platform depended on implicit trust in ACME's directory and on informal checks scattered throughout the code. To operate as a shared cloud service, C^3 would need clear boundaries: strong separation between tenants, federated identity for customer logins, and a common authorization layer capable of enforcing both global and tenant-specific rules.

C^3's engineers didn't want to abandon the system's successful relationship-based sharing model. The ReBAC rules governing document sharing within each workspace still made sense. The challenge was adding a new outer layer of authorization around that model, one that managed multi-tenant isolation, identity federation, and policy governance. In other words, they needed to externalize decisions into a policy engine that could enforce